

Eggplant Grow Guide

For eggplant seedlings, home gardens, containers, and small farm production

Crop	Eggplant / Aubergine / Garden egg types
Scientific name	Solanum melongena
Best use	Cooked vegetable fruit for stews, roasting, frying, curry, grilling
Guide focus	Transplanting seedlings, care, feeding, pests, diseases, harvesting

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

1. Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

What you see	Likely cause	What to do first
Many tiny round holes in young leaves	Flea beetles	Protect young plants, check daily, use row cover/netting if possible, and treat early before leaves are badly damaged.
Seedling cut off at soil line	Cutworms	Check soil around plant base in evening/morning; remove caterpillars; use collars around young stems.
Leaves yellow, curl inward, then dry brown	Verticillium wilt or root stress	Check soil drainage; remove badly wilted plants; rotate away from tomato/pepper/potato/eggplant area for 3-4 years.
Leaves bronzed, dusty, with fine webbing	Spider mites	Spray undersides, reduce drought stress, improve watering, repeat every 3-5 days if pests remain.
Sticky leaves, white insects flying	Whiteflies / aphids	Spray undersides, use sticky traps, remove weeds, repeat treatment every 3-5 days.
Plant has many leaves but few flowers	Too much nitrogen or poor light	Give 6-8 hours sun; reduce heavy nitrogen; use balanced/fruiting support.
Flowers drop, no fruit	Heat, water stress, poor pollination	Water evenly, mulch, gently shake flowers in morning, reduce stress.
Fruit skin dull, seeds brown	Overmature fruit	Harvest earlier while fruit is glossy, firm, and full-sized.
Tough or leathery fruit	Water stress, heat, overmaturity	Water 1-2 inches weekly; harvest on time; avoid letting mature fruit hang too long.

2. Quick Numbers Page

Item	Specific range / target
Crop family	Solanaceae - related to tomato, pepper, potato, and tobacco
Best temperature	70-85°F / 21-29°C
Seedling age before transplant	8-10 weeks from sowing
Good transplant size	5-8 inches tall with 6-9 leaves
Hardening-off time	7-14 days
Plant spacing	18-24 inches between plants
Row spacing	30-36 inches between rows
Container minimum	5-gallon bucket per plant
Soil pH target	6.0-7.0; acceptable 5.5-6.5 in some garden guides
Water target	1-2 inches per week, deep watering
Days to harvest from transplant	70-85 days
Days to harvest from seed	100-150 days
Fruit development after flowering	10-20 days to full mature size
Common harvest size	6-8 inches long for many standard types
Storage after harvest	About 7 days at cool conditions; avoid very cold storage

Note: exact size and harvest time change by variety. Long Asian types, round types, white types, and mini types may be harvested smaller or earlier than standard large purple eggplant.

3. Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Eggplant is a warm-season fruiting crop. It needs more heat and stronger light than lettuce and herbs, but it still needs steady water to avoid tough fruit and blossom/fruit problems.

Need	Target
Sunlight	6-8 hours direct sun daily
Best soil	Rich, loose, well-drained soil with organic matter
Soil pH	6.0-7.0 preferred
Water	1-2 inches weekly; containers may need water more often
Mulch	Use mulch after soil is warm; keep mulch slightly away from stem
Airflow	Space plants enough to reduce leaf wetness and disease pressure

Watering rule:

- Water deeply at the base of the plant, not over the leaves.
- Do not allow the root zone to swing from bone-dry to waterlogged.
- In pots, check moisture daily during hot weather.
- Irregular watering can cause tough fruit, poor flowering, root stress, and disease issues.

4. Feeding Guide

Eggplant is a heavier feeder than many herbs. Feed enough for steady growth, but do not overdo nitrogen because that can give big leafy plants with delayed flowering and fruiting.

Stage	Timing	Feeding direction
Before planting	Before transplant	Mix compost into soil. Use a balanced fertilizer if soil is weak.
At transplant	Day 0	Use compost and water well. Avoid strong fertilizer touching roots.
Settling period	First 7-10 days	Focus on watering and recovery; do not overfeed stressed seedlings.
Early growth	2-4 weeks after transplant	Light balanced feeding if plants are pale or slow.
Flowering/fruiting	4-8 weeks after transplant	Use fruiting support with potassium; avoid excess nitrogen.
Container plants	Every 2-4 weeks	Use light feeding because nutrients wash out faster in pots.

Signs of too much nitrogen: very dark lush leaves, weak flowering, soft growth, delayed fruiting, and more pest pressure.

5. Harvesting Guide

Harvest sign	What it means
Glossy, firm skin	Good harvest stage
Fruit close to full variety size	Ready to pick
Thumbnail press leaves slight dent	Ripe enough for many standard types
Dull skin and brown seeds	Overmature - quality has dropped
Fruit hanging too long	Reduces new production and quality

How to harvest:

- Use scissors, a knife, or a pruner. Do not pull fruit from the plant.
- Leave a short stem on the fruit.
- Wear gloves if stems or calyxes are prickly.
- Harvest every 3-7 days when plants are producing strongly.
- Pick mature fruit quickly so the plant keeps flowering and setting more fruit.

Common range: many standard types are harvested around 6-8 inches long, but mini, round, white, and long Asian eggplants may have different best harvest sizes.

6. Leaf and Fruit Problem Guide

Plant sign	Possible cause	First response
Pale green leaves	Low nitrogen, poor roots, low light	Check sun and water; feed lightly after plant is established.
Lower leaves yellow and curl inward	Verticillium wilt, root stress	Check drainage; avoid replanting nightshades in same spot.
Tiny holes all over leaves	Flea beetles	Act early; protect young plants; monitor daily.
Bleached/bronzed leaves	Spider mites, drought stress	Spray undersides; improve water consistency.
Leaves wilt midday but recover evening	Heat stress	Water deeply and mulch; provide temporary shade if extreme.
Leaves wilt and do not recover	Root rot, wilt disease	Check roots/soil; remove collapsed plants if disease is likely.
Sunken spots on fruit	Anthrachnose/fruit rot or injury	Remove affected fruit; improve airflow; avoid leaving overmature fruit.
Pale burned patches on fruit	Sunscald	Maintain leaf cover and steady water; avoid over-pruning.

7. Flowering and Fruiting Problems

Problem	Likely cause	What to do
Flowers drop	Heat, drought, water swings, weak pollination	Water evenly, mulch, avoid stress, shake flowers gently in morning.
Lots of leaves, few flowers	Too much nitrogen or too little sun	Reduce high-nitrogen feeding; give 6-8 hours sun.
Small fruit stops growing	Poor water, root stress, pests	Check soil moisture, leaf health, and pest pressure.
Fruit tough/leathery	Heat, drought, overmaturity	Water evenly and harvest earlier.
Fruit touches soil and rots	Plant unsupported or low fruit	Stake/cage plant; mulch; harvest lower fruit early.

Pollination note:

Eggplant flowers can self-pollinate, but wind, vibration, and insects help. In still conditions, gently shake the plant or tap flower stems in the morning to help pollen move.

8. Small Farmer Notes

- Use healthy, sturdy seedlings: 5-8 inches tall, 6-9 leaves, dark green, no active pest pressure.
- Space plants 18-24 inches in rows 30-36 inches apart for better airflow and harvest access.
- Rotate away from tomato, pepper, potato, eggplant, and tobacco family crops for 3-4 years where possible.
- Stake or cage plants before fruit load becomes heavy.
- Scout twice weekly for flea beetles, whiteflies, aphids, mites, caterpillars, wilt, and fruit spots.
- Harvest glossy fruit frequently to keep production moving.
- Grade fruit after harvest: remove bruised, dull, overmature, or pest-damaged fruit.

Field harvest tip: keep picked fruit shaded and cool. Do not leave harvested eggplant in direct sun.

9. Home Garden and Container Notes

Situation	Recommended setup
2-6 plants in yard	Plant 18-24 inches apart in full sun with support.
Container growing	Use at least one 5-gallon bucket per plant; 7-10 gallons is better for larger varieties.
Balcony/patio	Use a heavy pot, drainage holes, stake/cage, and 6-8 hours sun.
Small space	Choose smaller-fruited or compact varieties when available.
Hot dry location	Mulch and water deeply; pots may need daily checks.

Container warning:

- Never allow the pot to sit in standing water.
- Do not let the container dry out repeatedly once flowering starts.
- Use support early because fruit can pull branches down or break them.

10. Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

Eggplant is in the same family as tomato, pepper, potato, and tobacco. Clean handling helps reduce disease spread, especially when moving between seedlings, beds, or different nightshade crops.

Tobacco and smoker warning:

- Do not smoke and then handle eggplant seedlings without washing hands.
- Do not rest cigarettes or tobacco near seedling trays or pots.
- Wash hands with soap and water before handling seedlings.
- Clean scissors/pruners before harvesting or pruning.
- If you touch a sick plant, wash hands before touching healthy plants.

Why this matters: Tobacco Mosaic Virus and related tobamoviruses can affect eggplant and other nightshade crops. Prevention is easier than cure.

11. Hardening Off Seedlings

Hardening off means gradually preparing seedlings for direct sun, wind, and outdoor conditions before permanent planting.

Day	Exposure plan
Day 1-2	Bright shade or gentle morning sun for 2-3 hours.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 3-4 hours; protect from strong afternoon sun.
Day 5-7	Longer outdoor time; avoid cold, heavy wind, or dry trays.
Day 8-14	Fuller outdoor exposure if seedlings stay firm and green.

Bring seedlings back to protection if night temperature is below 55°F / 13°C, if leaves wilt badly, or if wind is strong.

12. Transplanting From Trays or Small Pots

Not every customer is transplanting from trays, but for customers buying seedlings this section is important. Eggplant dislikes cold roots and rough transplanting.

Best time of day:

- Early morning before 9:00 a.m. or late evening after 4:30 p.m.
- Avoid the hottest part of the day.
- Water seedlings 1-2 hours before transplanting.

Step-by-step:

- Prepare holes before removing seedlings from the tray or pot.
- Keep the root ball intact.
- Plant at the same depth as the pot/tray soil line.
- Press soil gently around roots; do not compact hard.
- Water immediately after planting.
- Stake or cage early if the variety gets heavy.
- Check daily for the first 7 days.

Remove early flowers or tiny fruit on weak transplants so the plant can focus on roots and strong branches first.

13. Common Pests

Pest	Signs	First actions
Flea beetles	Tiny round shot-holes in leaves, worse on young plants	Protect seedlings; use row cover/netting; monitor daily; treat early if damage spreads.
Aphids	Clusters on new growth, sticky leaves, ants	Spray off; use mild soap spray; control ants; repeat 3-5 days.
Whiteflies	White insects fly up, sticky leaves, yellowing	Spray undersides; use sticky traps; keep weeds down.
Spider mites	Bronzed leaves, dustiness, fine webbing	Improve moisture; spray undersides; repeat 3-5 days.
Colorado potato beetle	Yellow/orange larvae or striped adults eating leaves	Handpick early; inspect undersides for eggs; remove larvae.
Caterpillars/hornworms	Large holes, chewed leaves or fruit, droppings	Check morning/evening; handpick; use safe biological control if available.
Thrips	Silvery streaks, distorted young growth/flowers	Remove badly damaged parts; monitor flowers; use sticky traps.

14. Common Diseases

Disease/problem	Signs	First actions
Verticillium wilt	Lower leaves yellow, curl inward, wilt, dry brown	Remove badly affected plants; rotate crops; avoid nightshade replanting same spot.
Leaf blight/leaf spot	Dark spots on leaves, stems, or fruit; defoliation	Remove affected leaves; water at base; improve airflow.
Root rot	Wilting, yellowing, wet soil, weak roots	Improve drainage; reduce watering; avoid standing water.
Damping-off	Young seedling collapses near soil line	Use clean media; avoid overwatering; improve airflow.
Tobacco Mosaic Virus	Mottled/mosaic leaves, distorted growth, poor production	Sanitation; avoid tobacco contamination; remove severely affected plants.
Phytophthora blight	Dark stem/branch areas, collapse in wet conditions	Improve drainage; avoid waterlogged beds; remove affected plants.
Anthracnose/fruit rot	Sunken spots on fruit, worse on mature fruit	Harvest on time; remove infected fruit; improve airflow.

15. ParaLife Trees Support

Need help with your eggplant seedlings?

Send clear photos by WhatsApp so the problem can be checked properly.

- Photo of the full plant
- Close-up of the top leaves
- Underside of damaged leaves
- Stem/base at soil level
- Fruit damage, flower drop, or insects if visible
- Photo of the soil or container

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Sources used for crop guidance include University of Delaware Cooperative Extension, University of Minnesota Extension, Virginia Cooperative Extension, Utah State University Extension, and UC IPM eggplant pest management resources.